



△ Sombrero Galaxy

Also known as M104, this edge-on spiral galaxy resembles a sombrero hat, its brim edged by a dark lane of dust. Situated on the border with the constellation Corvus, the Sombrero Galaxy is about 30 million light-years away.

VIRGO THE VIRGIN

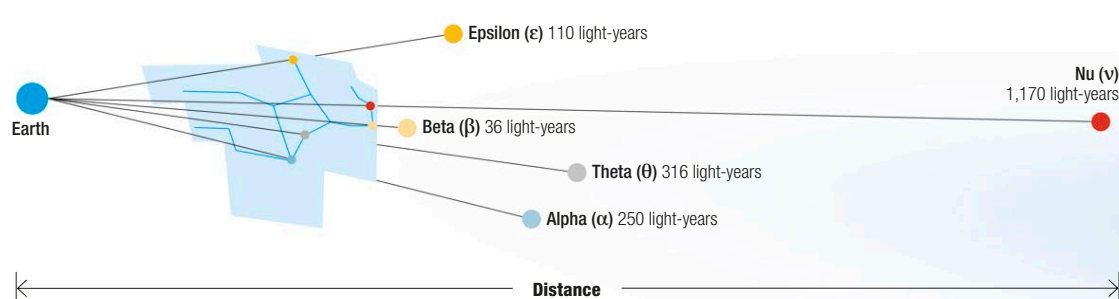
VIRGO IS THE LARGEST CONSTELLATION IN THE ZODIAC, AND ALSO THE SECOND LARGEST IN THE ENTIRE SKY. IT CONTAINS THE MAJOR CLUSTER OF GALAXIES CLOSEST TO US, AS WELL AS THE BRIGHTEST QUASAR.

Virgo had several identities in ancient Greek mythology. In one story, she represented Demeter, the corn goddess, and was depicted as holding an ear of grain marked by the constellation's brightest star, Spica. Usually, though, she was equated with Dike, the goddess of justice, and the adjoining constellation Libra was visualized as her scales of justice.

The constellation is shaped like a sloping letter Y, with Spica at the base. In the bowl of the Y is situated the Virgo Cluster, some 55 million light-years away. This cluster of galaxies has more than 2,000 members, the brightest of which can be seen through a small telescope. So large is the cluster that it spills over Virgo's northern border into the adjacent constellation of Coma Berenices. At the heart of the Virgo Cluster is the giant elliptical galaxy M87. The brightest quasar (see pp.60–61) as seen from Earth, 3C 273, also lies in Virgo but is over 50 times farther away than the Virgo Cluster.

▷ Star distances

The nearest of Virgo's pattern stars is Zavijava (β Virginis) at 36 light-years away. The brightest star, Spica (α Virginis), is much more distant, at about 250 light-years away. The most distant pattern star is Nu (ν) Virginis, which is about 1,170 light-years from Earth.



Virgo's M87 is one of the most massive local galaxies, with a mass of almost 3 trillion Suns